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CABLEGATE

Disclosure is not merely an action; it is a way of life. To my mind it carries both sense and sensibility: you are what you know, and no state has the right to make you less than you are. Many modern states forget that they were founded on the principles of the Enlightenment, that knowledge is a guarantor of liberty, and that no state has the right to dispense justice as if it were merely a favour of power. Justice, in fact, rightly upheld, is a check on power, and we can only look after the people by making sure that politics never controls information absolutely.

This is common sense. It used to be the first principle of journalism in every country with a free press. The Internet has made it easier to censor writing, removing the existence of truth at the flick of a mouse (Stalin would've loved it) and monitoring people's private data in ways that would have proved delightful to the demon paper-shufflers of the Third Reich. Secrecy is too often the sole preserve of the powerful, and anyone who says so, these days, is not just taken to be underscoring an old liberal standard and a canard of democracy, but to be revealing themselves as an exotic anarchist bent on 'compromising national security'. The principles laid down in the American Constitution would, if properly examined, look radical to the mindset of a vast number of people living in America today. Jefferson would seem like an enemy of the state and Madison a pinko guerrilla. Likewise, to the modern Chinese, those studious little economists Marx and Engels would appear like madmen who little understood the deep human value of a Gucci handbag and the new iPad.

Information sets us free. And it does so by allowing us to question the actions of those who would sooner we had no means to question them, no right to reply. WikiLeaks, for all its modernism and all its software, is a force for the upholding of liberty that would have seemed quite traditional and quite sensible to the mind of an eighteenth-century figure such as John Wilkes. We come under fire, very often, for upholding those principles that